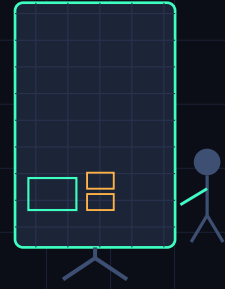


The Design Pitch

Language, Narrative & Persuasion

B2 Worksheet · Professional English for Designers, Architects & Creative Directors



ACTIVITY 1 OF 3

Reading Comprehension & Vocabulary

Multiple Choice · 7 Questions · choose the best option



Each question places you in a real professional pitch moment. Choose the phrase that signals genuine design thinking.

Instructions: Each question presents a scenario from a professional design pitch. Circle or underline the letter of the best answer (A, B, C or D). After completing all seven questions, check your answers on the Answer Key page.

Q1.

A junior designer is presenting her concept for a cultural centre to a panel of clients. She wants to open with a strong statement about the idea's origin.

Which phrase would most effectively open a design narrative?

- | | |
|---|---|
| <p>A This project is basically about making a building near the waterfront area.</p> | <p>B The concept grew out of a tension between public accessibility and private contemplation.</p> |
| <p>C We decided to use concrete because it was suggested by the structural engineer.</p> | <p>D The brief asked for a 2,000 sq metre facility with flexible seating options.</p> |

Q2.

A designer is explaining why the spatial layout of her proposal is unconventional. She wants to justify her reasoning without sounding defensive.

Which phrase introduces a design decision in the most confident and professional way?

- | | |
|--|---|
| <p>A We tried to do something different because the usual approach felt limiting to us.</p> | <p>B The client didn't specify this, but we felt it might be worth exploring further.</p> |
| <p>C Rather than defaulting to a conventional corridor typology, we organised spaces around a central void.</p> | <p>D As you can see, we moved things around to make it feel more modern and interesting.</p> |

Q3.

During a pitch, a client says: 'I am not sure this fits our brand identity.' The designer needs to respond constructively.

Which response best demonstrates professional communication and keeps the conversation productive?

A That's a valid concern. Could you help me understand which elements feel misaligned? That would let us refine the direction together.

B We actually think it does fit your brand — the moodboard we showed earlier makes that quite clear.

C Brand identity is quite subjective, so it is hard to say definitively whether it truly fits.

D We can change anything — just tell us your preference and we will adjust the whole concept.

Q4.

A designer needs to explain an abstract concept — that a building should dissolve into its landscape rather than impose upon it.

Which sentence most clearly articulates this design intention to a non-specialist client?

A We are using low-carbon materials to reduce the environmental footprint of the structure.

B The building is designed to feel as though it has always been part of the site — its edges blur into the terrain.

C The roof will be planted and the exterior cladding will use natural tones from a site palette.

D We referenced several precedents from Scandinavian landscape architecture to inform our approach.

Q5.

At the end of a pitch, the designer wants to invite questions and signal that the proposal is still open to iteration.

Which closing statement best balances confidence with openness to further dialogue?

A This is our final proposal and we are fully confident it satisfies the brief as it was stated.

B We are honestly not yet sure this is the right direction — we would love your thoughts first.

C We are presenting this as a strong direction rather than a fixed solution — we would welcome your reactions.

D Please take your time to review the drawings and we will follow up by email next week.

Q6.

A designer is explaining the narrative thread that connects all the design decisions in a residential project.

What does the term 'design narrative' most accurately refer to in a professional context?

A The chronological story of the construction process from planning to project completion

B The written description submitted alongside formal planning permission applications

C A coherent framework of ideas that gives meaning and logic to each design decision

D The marketing text used to promote a completed project in press releases or social media

Q7.

A product designer says: 'We need to foreground the material qualities in the presentation — tactility is central to the concept.'

What does the word 'foreground' mean in this sentence?

A

To physically position the object at the front of the display table during the presentation

B

To emphasise something or make it the most prominent element of the presentation

C

To photograph the object against a simple, uncluttered neutral background for slides

D

To carry out materials research and testing before the design process formally begins

Sort the Pitch Vocabulary

Word Sorting · 12 Items · drag each phrase into the correct column



Drag each phrase into the correct category. Recognising functional vocabulary is key to structuring a persuasive design pitch.

Instructions: The 12 phrases below are used in professional design pitches. Write each phrase in the correct column: **Starting a Narrative**, **Describing a Concept**, or **Responding to Feedback**. Each phrase belongs to one category only.

WORD BANK

The driving idea behind this...	The concept stems from...	conceptually driven by
That feedback helps us refine...	We can absolutely revisit...	That's a useful point —
At the heart of this proposal...	Could you say more about...	rooted in contrast
What we set out to explore...	an honest expression of	a spatial tension between

SORT INTO CATEGORIES:

STARTING A NARRATIVE	DESCRIBING A CONCEPT	RESPONDING TO FEEDBACK
1.	1.	1.
2.	2.	2.
3.	3.	3.
4.	4.	4.

Complete the Design Pitch

Gap-Fill · 5 Sentences · choose the correct phrase from the options given



A designer presents a concept for a community library. Drag the phrase that fits grammatically and conceptually.

Instructions: A designer is presenting a concept for a new community library. Read each sentence and circle the letter of the phrase (A, B, C or D) that correctly completes the gap. Consider both grammatical fit and professional tone.

1. The idea for this library _____ the community's need for a space that feels both intimate and open to the public.

- | | | | |
|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------|--------------------------------------|--|
| A was inspired somewhat by | B grew directly out of | C found its basis coming from | D was conceptually founded upon |
|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------|--------------------------------------|--|

2. Rather than separating reading areas from gathering spaces, _____ them through a series of layered thresholds that users can navigate intuitively.

- | | | | |
|------------------------------|--------------------------------|--------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| A we chose to connect | B we decided on linking | C our proposal combines | D our solution is connecting |
|------------------------------|--------------------------------|--------------------------------|-------------------------------------|

3. The materiality of the building _____ the surrounding landscape: raw timber and rammed earth echo the textures of the site.

- | | | | |
|--------------------------------------|--|-------------------------------------|---|
| A takes its cues closely from | B has been influenced directly by | C is in direct dialogue with | D makes clear references towards |
|--------------------------------------|--|-------------------------------------|---|

4. We understand your concern about budget — and _____ those constraints as opportunities to simplify and intensify the concept, not dilute it.

- | | | | |
|--|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| A our intention would be treating | B we could possibly consider | C we are suggesting to handle | D we would like to reframe |
|--|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|

5. Ultimately, what we are proposing is not simply a building — _____ a civic gesture: a space that expresses the community's belief in shared knowledge.

- | | | | |
|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| A it is an attempt to make | B but rather we are creating | C what this represents here is | D instead this is about making |
|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|

REFLECTION

Choose one sentence from Activity 3. Rewrite it in your own words, adapting it to a design project you are currently working on or have worked on in the past. Try to use at least two vocabulary items from Activity 2 in your version.

ANSWER KEY

For teacher and self-study use. Do not consult this page until you have completed all three activities.

Activity 1 — Multiple Choice

Q1. Correct answer: **B — The concept grew out of a tension between public accessibility and private contemplation.**

Why this answer: Option B uses 'grew out of' — implying organic development — and frames the idea around a compelling tension. Design pitches should open with an idea, not a specification or technical constraint.

Q2. Correct answer: **C — Rather than defaulting to a conventional corridor typology, we organised spaces around a central void.**

Why this answer: 'Rather than defaulting to' signals a deliberate, informed choice — showing the designer is aware of convention and has consciously departed from it. This is a key structure: acknowledge the norm, then explain your departure.

Q3. Correct answer: **A — That's a valid concern. Could you help me understand which elements feel misaligned? That would let us refine the direction together.**

Why this answer: Option A uses active listening ('valid concern'), asks a clarifying question, and proposes collaboration. In professional contexts, inviting dialogue is a sign of confidence, not weakness.

Q4. Correct answer: **B — The building is designed to feel as though it has always been part of the site — its edges blur into the terrain.**

Why this answer: Option B translates an abstract concept ('dissolving') into vivid, accessible language. Good design communication makes poetic ideas tangible without being vague or overly technical.

Q5. Correct answer: **C — We are presenting this as a strong direction rather than a fixed solution — we would welcome your reactions.**

Why this answer: Option C is precise: 'strong direction, not fixed solution' is honest and collaborative. 'Welcome your reactions' is confident but open. A is too closed; B too uncertain; D defers without engaging.

Q6. Correct answer: **C — A coherent framework of ideas that gives meaning and logic to each design decision**

Why this answer: A 'design narrative' is the conceptual thread that connects and justifies each decision. It is not a timeline, a legal document, or marketing copy — it is the 'why' that gives the work coherence and purpose.

Q7. Correct answer: **B — To emphasise something or make it the most prominent element of the presentation**

Why this answer: 'To foreground' means to bring something to prominence — to make it central and unavoidable in the audience's attention. It is widely used in design, cultural studies, and academic writing.

Activity 2 — Word Sorting

Starting a Narrative	The concept stems from...
Starting a Narrative	What we set out to explore...
Starting a Narrative	At the heart of this proposal...
Starting a Narrative	The driving idea behind this...

Describing a Concept	rooted in contrast
Describing a Concept	a spatial tension between
Describing a Concept	conceptually driven by
Describing a Concept	an honest expression of
Responding to Feedback	That's a useful point —
Responding to Feedback	We can absolutely revisit...
Responding to Feedback	Could you say more about...
Responding to Feedback	That feedback helps us refine...

Activity 3 — Complete the Design Pitch

Sentence 1. Answer: **B — "grew directly out of"**

Why this answer: 'Grew directly out of' suggests the design emerged organically from a real observation or need.

Sentence 2. Answer: **A — "we chose to connect"**

Why this answer: 'We chose to connect' is clean, active, and decisive — signalling a deliberate design decision.

Sentence 3. Answer: **C — "is in direct dialogue with"**

Why this answer: 'In dialogue with' implies a two-way, active relationship between building and context.

Sentence 4. Answer: **D — "we would like to reframe"**

Why this answer: 'Reframe' means to present a challenge in a new, more productive light — constructive and confident.

Sentence 5. Answer: **A — "it is an attempt to make"**

Why this answer: 'It is an attempt to make' is both ambitious and honest — elevating the project without overpromising.

ACTIVITY	POSSIBLE SCORE	YOUR SCORE
Activity 1 — Multiple Choice	7	/ 7
Activity 2 — Word Sorting	12	/ 12
Activity 3 — Complete the Pitch	5	/ 5
TOTAL	24	/ 24